

BEST

Management Advice

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“DESIGN THINKING HAS GREAT VALUE IN STRATEGY”

Q What is Design Thinking (DT) and why should it be incorporated in companies?

Design Thinking is a process of innovation that begins with user needs and aspirations as solutions are developed. The reasons for incorporating it are simple—it is a significant driver of both profit and impact. DT is not limited to aesthetics; it touches every aspect of user experience and drives brand recognition.

Q What are the challenges that you see for managers and team leaders while using DT?

A spreadsheet and a sketch are essentially different ways of expressing a future vision, but finding a common language between design and other functions requires time and effort. With huge amounts of data, the synthesis can be even more difficult. DT involves multiple iterations and requires commitment and attention to nuance—pursuit of the “why”. However, rapid prototyping, user feedback



and focus on user needs can help teams overcome these challenges.

Q I understand that it is a human-centric approach to problem solving. In this age of AI is there a contradiction between AI and DT?

Not necessarily. As with other fields, AI can rapidly accelerate parts of the design process, spur creativity, and reduce cost. However, people connect with stories as much as the design itself. The “prompt” designers create has a profound impact

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on access and inclusion. There is still a huge role for human imagination and empathy in deciding which

problems and people to create for.

Q Are there areas of management (like marketing or product design) where DT would be more useful than others?

The value of DT in marketing and innovation is generally well accepted. In uncertain times, DT actually has great value in strategy. Companies have to address complex issues such as inequality and sustainability today. The approaches have to be acceptable to very diverse stakeholders. These tensions cannot be resolved by debate—they can only be moved forward with experimentation. DT is ideally suited for creating options that enable progress.

Q How can the outcome of DT be measured?

The simple fact that there are so many new consumer segments today show how much user needs guide innovation today. DT is sometimes seen as a “soft” approach, but the results are concrete. When executed well, the critical business metrics move sales, customer engagement, brand recognition and loyalty. DT also drives emotional connection with brands. **BT**

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